Optimizing Openness in Human Subjects Research: Balancing Transparency and Protection

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International Association for Social Science Information Service & Technology

QDR
The Qualitative Data Repository

Data Sharing Factors

- Researchers → *implementing actors*
- Funder and publisher requirements → *enforcing factors*
  - Multiplying benefits of resources spent
  - Transparency and better evaluation of publications
- Technological and infrastructure advances → *enabling factors*
  - A lot of contemporary data are born digital
  - Dedicated research data services and training at university libraries
  - Professional repositories (domain and institutional) develop processes and tools to store, make findable, preserve for the long run

- IRBs → *hurdles*?

Motivation for QDR's Empirical Studies of IRBs

- Researchers come to repositories wishing to share data but oftentimes present restrictive consent forms
- Reveals little awareness of the need for DMP choices and IC scripts to align
- No habit of planning for sharing; ongoing use of outdated IC templates

Research Question: Does this experience reveal counter advice received or absence of guidance from IRBs?

2019 IRBs and Data Sharing Study

What we did:

2019 IRBs and Data Sharing Study Details

- 17 universities in individual interviews
- 12 additional universities in focus groups (Chicago; DC)
- Primarily R1 universities (due both to sample selection and self-selection):
  - Highest NSF SBE funding amounts
  - Most relevant pressures from federal funders and journal requirements on researchers
  - Better resourced human research protection programs → often trend-setters for others

2019 IRBs and Data Sharing Study
Data: https://doi.org/10.5064/F6RQA7AQ

2019 IRBs and Data Sharing Study

What we found:

Where IRBs first learn about data sharing (expected answers)

From researchers' protocols

- Suggests need for new knowledge by IRBs
  - Some staff research further on their own
  - Most have to rely on researchers' own understanding
  - Due to legal considerations, must involve other dept's
- No institutional (internal or external) guidance mentioned as an initiating driver

Where IRBs first learn about data sharing (less expected)

- From various data use agreements (DUAs) that researchers sign as secondary users of data

- From PIs' need to cooperate internally on a team or with researchers at other institutions or to take "their" data with them to other universities
  - more limited type of data sharing, but still necessitates detailed plans

- Sometimes even from media reports about science fraud scandals

IRB policy development follows researcher practice

Respondents recognized that this:

- Reflects idiosyncrasies of studies
- Leads to a*d hoc* solutions
- Might nonetheless be the right approach, at least for a while

BUT all respondents wished for a centralized source of more uniform information / standardized forms

Most Common Reaction – Change of Application Forms

- Typically, questions about data storage (during course of project) and disposition already existed

- Recently (last 2-3 years) – new questions added
  - Will the data be shared in any form?
  - Will shared data be de-identified or not?
  - What will be the period of retention?

Less Common – Proactive IRBing

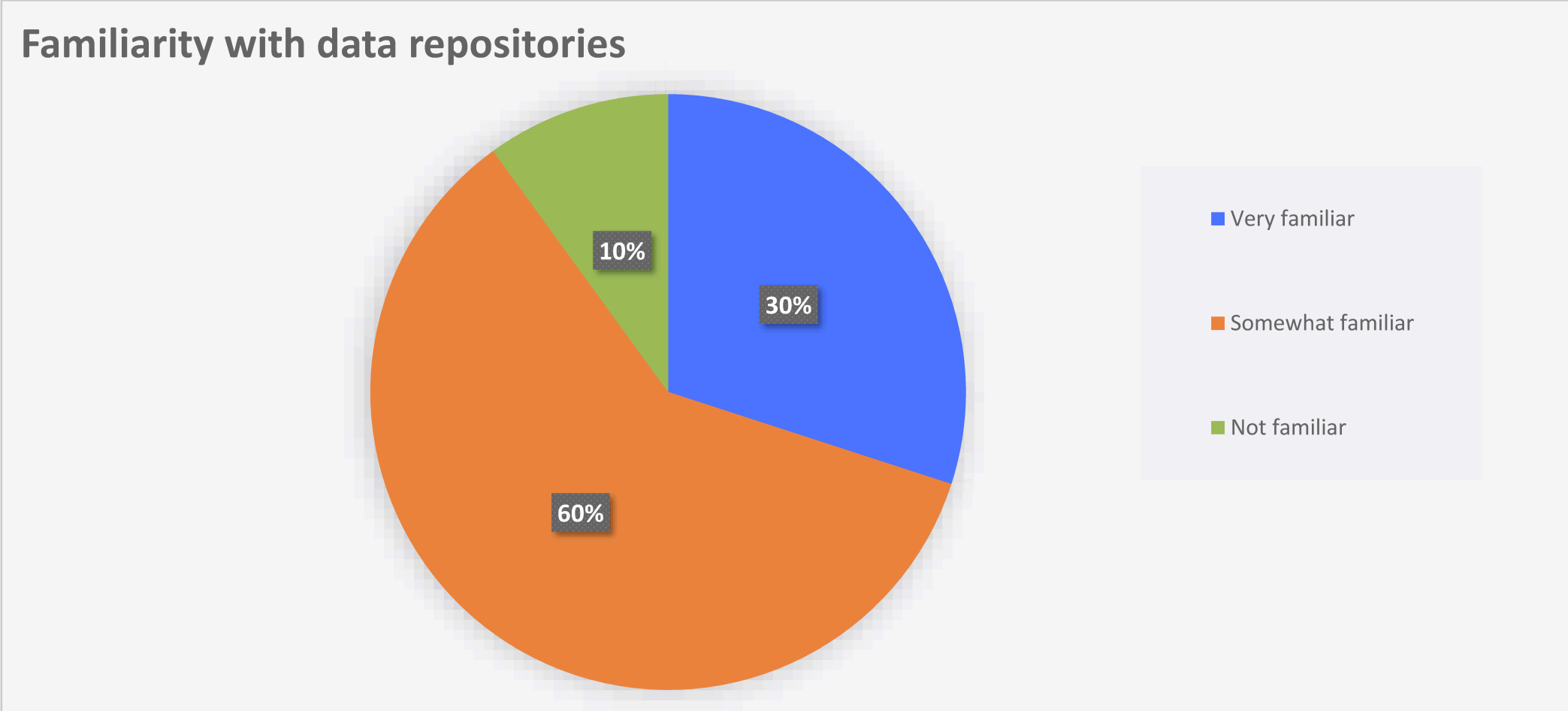
- Being alert to funder requirements generally
- Discouraging PIs from promising that they / their team will be the only ones with access to the data
- Inquiring about data sharing plans if none are addressed in IRB application

Least Common – Shift in Mindset

- Rare examples of thinking about data sharing as a benefit, not just a risk

"In submissions, people will say…'This might lead to increased knowledge about X'… and we take that on faith, but if that data never gets out into the scientific community and is never shared, that benefit can't be realized."

Level of awareness of data repositories specifically

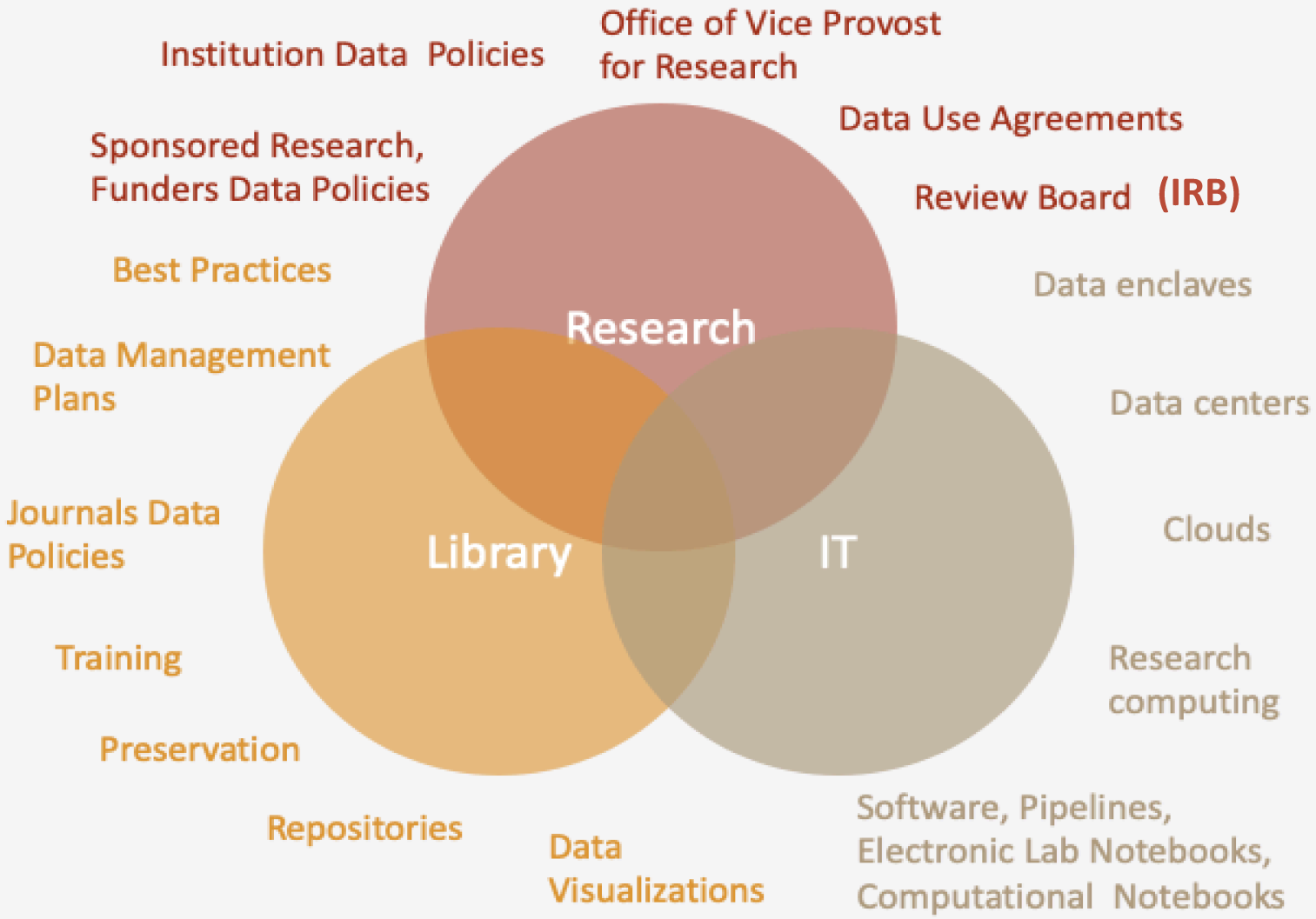


Lessons:
Towards Holistic Data Management

Need for Intra-campus and Inter-institutional Coordination

- Issues are complex and solutions require multifaceted expertise
- Reorganizations of activities in past 7-10 years: trend toward expanding scope of human participant protections programs to become broader research integrity programs
- Most typically also involve sponsored programs, local libraries, IT departments, legal counsel

Collective Management of Tensions



What You as Data Professionals Can Do to Help

- Join or initiate a coordination group (e.g., Research Data Stewards) to contribute RDS perspective
- Reach out personally to colleagues at IRB / HRPP / OSP/ cyber-infrastructure offices
- Draw up a list of relevant resources across campus with brief description for PIs
- If consulting on DMP, ask PI for consent script too
- If training on DMP, highlight the DMP/IRB nexus and need for alignment

DMP / IRB Nexus – Project-level Recommendations

- PIs must consider post-study life of their data
- Human participants must be informed of the data sharing plans and given opt-in / opt-out choices
- Data sharing allows for nuance – find the appropriate choices for a given study and a given population
- Suggested consent script inserts for data sharing: https://qdr.syr.edu/guidance/templates#informed-consent

What We at QDR Are Doing Further

- Updating a 2017 IRB Public Guidance Language Study
- Initiating an #SBERdatasharing tag to focus discussions on this topic at PRIM&R
- Promulgating consent script insert for data sharing

https://qdr.syr.edu/guidance/templates#informed-consent

- Conducing workshops for researchers at several disciplinary associations to compare their IRB-related data sharing experiences with these findings

Questions? Comments?

Please stay in touch:

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